

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Project Management English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For project managers, program managers, PMO staff, scrum masters, delivery leads, operations managers, and cross-functional coordinators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Project Charter and Scope Definition

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Schedule, Critical Path, and Dependencies

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

03 Risk Register and Issue Escalation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Stakeholder Alignment and Governance

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

05 Change Requests and Scope Creep

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

06 Status Reporting and Executive Updates

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

07 Vendor and Cross-Functional Delivery

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

08 Post-Implementation Review

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Project Charter and Scope Definition

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A sponsor requests a dashboard but the brief does not define users, decisions, or excluded features.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: charter, scope, assumption, exclusion.

Model response

Who will use the dashboard, and what decision should it support? Let's agree on those needs and the exclusions before we estimate the work or call the scope complete.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Who will use the warehouse dashboard? - Fictional charter discussion: a sponsor has requested a warehouse dashboard without defining its users or boundaries.
2. Moving records without cleaning every record - Fictional archive project: a coordinator and sponsor define a migration involving 4,000 historical records.
3. A pilot is not a regional rollout - Fictional booking-system kickoff: the brief names one training center, while a stakeholder expects three centers.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Does training include contractors?

In a fictional equipment-tracking project, the charter includes training 12 employees. A coordinator asks whether six contractors are included. Their access needs and available training time are unknown. Agree what must be clarified before extending the scope.

Role A: Project manager: explain the current boundary and ask about the contractor use case.

Role B: Facilities coordinator: request contractor training without assuming access or additional funding is approved.

Possible opening: The charter covers 12 employees; could you clarify what the six contractors need to do?

Success checks

- Distinguish the agreed audience from the requested addition.
- Identify access and training-time assumptions.
- Agree who will clarify the requirement before a commitment.

Add a complication: The coordinator calls contractor training a minor detail that should not affect scope.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Schedule, Critical Path, and Dependencies

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A testing task is three days late and blocks the release rehearsal. Other work is on schedule.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: critical path, dependency, milestone, buffer.

Model response

Testing is three days late and is blocking the release rehearsal. Other tasks remain on schedule. I'll show the dependency and the proposed recovery options in the schedule update.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. A - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 · Conversations

1. Testing blocks the rehearsal - Fictional release update using the lesson case: testing is three days late and blocks the release rehearsal; other work is on schedule.
2. The furniture delivery has spare time - Fictional office project: furniture delivery slips two days; its schedule has four days of buffer, while network approval remains pending.

3. Overlapping work needs a checked dependency - Fictional museum installation: label proofreading is complete, but printing depends on curator approval that has not arrived.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | One interpreter, two milestones

A fictional project has two workshops on Thursday, both requiring the same interpreter. Each workshop is ready otherwise. The interpreter's availability has not been confirmed. Explain the shared dependency and agree the next scheduling check.

Role A: Scheduler: distinguish workshop preparation from resource confirmation.

Role B: Workshop lead: ask whether moving one workshop would solve the conflict without assuming availability.

Possible opening: Both workshops are prepared, but they still depend on the same unconfirmed interpreter.

Success checks

- Name the shared resource dependency.
- Keep preparation separate from delivery readiness.
- Agree to confirm availability before promising replacement times.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to mark both milestones complete because the slides are finished.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Risk Register and Issue Escalation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A risk register still lists a supplier delay as a possibility, although the supplier has confirmed it will miss the delivery date.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: risk register, issue log, mitigation, owner.

Model response

The delay is now a confirmed issue, not only a future risk. I'll update its status and ask the responsible owner to document the impact and next action.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. A possible delay becomes an issue - Fictional supplier review using the lesson case: the supplier has confirmed it will miss delivery, but the risk register still says possible delay.
2. The permit rumor needs evidence - Fictional venue project: a coordinator hears an unconfirmed rumor that a permit was rejected; the authority has issued no decision.

3. A backup exists but has not been tested - Fictional training launch: a risk register says backup laptops mitigate equipment shortages, but the eight stored laptops have not been checked.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An unavailable reviewer

In a fictional translation project, the sole reviewer confirms she cannot work next week. The review milestone is next Wednesday. A substitute has been suggested but has not accepted. Discuss the issue, possible mitigation, and escalation owner.

Role A: Project coordinator: report the confirmed absence and unresolved coverage.

Role B: Delivery manager: challenge any claim that the substitute has solved the problem.

Possible opening: The reviewer's absence is confirmed; replacement coverage is still only a proposal.

Success checks

- Separate absence evidence from coverage assumptions.
- Identify an owner and the affected milestone.
- Keep the issue open until replacement readiness is assessed.

Add a complication: Someone wants the issue closed after an invitation is sent to the substitute.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Stakeholder Alignment and Governance

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

A project meeting ends with several recommendations but no indication of who approves the change.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: governance, RACI, decision rights, steering committee.

Model response

We have a recommendation, but approval is still outstanding. Who has authority to approve this change, and what information do they need? I'll record the decision route in the meeting notes.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. B - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. A - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 • Conversations

1. Recommendations without an approver - Fictional governance meeting using the lesson case: participants have recommended a change, but approval authority is unclear.

2. Consulted does not mean accountable - Fictional training project: the agreed RACI names the training director as approver and the IT lead as consulted on platform changes.

3. The absent service desk needs a voice - Fictional steering discussion: leaders favor weekend deployment, but the service desk has not been consulted and support coverage is unknown.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Who can accept the pilot?

A fictional pilot has finished. The sponsor approves funding, the operations lead receives the service, and the charter does not name the acceptance decision-maker. Facilitate a short discussion to resolve authority before declaring acceptance.

Role A: Project manager: invite operational concerns and identify the missing decision right.

Role B: Operations lead: ask whether receiving the service gives you formal acceptance authority.

Possible opening: Delivery is finished, but the charter does not tell us who can formally accept the pilot.

Success checks

- Separate funding authority from acceptance authority.
- Invite the receiving team's perspective.
- Agree who will clarify governance before recording acceptance.

Add a complication: The sponsor's assistant says funding approval should count as acceptance.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Change Requests and Scope Creep

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A sponsor asks for a new report two weeks before launch. The team can add it only by moving another feature or extending the schedule.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: change request, scope creep, impact analysis, baseline.

Model response

We can assess the new report as a scope change. To include it, we would need to move another feature or extend the schedule. Which tradeoff should we develop for review?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 • Conversations

1. A late report needs a tradeoff - Fictional launch negotiation using the lesson case: a new report is requested two weeks before launch; it requires moving another feature or extending the schedule.
2. Five small additions make real work - Fictional portal project: five separate wording and layout requests arrived after scope approval; their combined effort has not been assessed.

3. Replacing a workshop with recordings - Fictional onboarding project: the approved scope includes two live workshops; a sponsor requests ten edited recordings instead.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A second language at the last review

A fictional visitor guide is approved in English. A stakeholder now requests a Spanish version. Translation and review estimates are unavailable, and the printing slot is fixed for next week. Negotiate an assessment route without promising delivery.

Role A: Project manager: explain which scope and schedule questions need review.

Role B: Visitor-services lead: explain why the additional language matters and consider phased delivery.

Possible opening: We can assess a Spanish version, but we do not yet know whether reviewed translation fits next week's printing slot.

Success checks

- Treat the addition as a change request.
- Offer a conditional phased option without inventing estimates.
- Identify the review and approval needed before changing the baseline.

Add a complication: The stakeholder offers to skip language review to preserve the date.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Status Reporting and Executive Updates

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A project is labeled green despite an unresolved dependency that threatens its planned date. The reporting criteria require material threats to be visible.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: status report, RAG status, trend, decision ask.

Model response

The current label does not show the unresolved dependency. I'll report the delivery threat, its impact, and the decision needed so the status reflects the agreed criteria.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. C - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. B - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. Green conceals the unresolved dependency - Fictional status review using the lesson case: an unresolved dependency threatens the date, and project reporting criteria require material threats to be visible.
2. Scanned is not accepted - Fictional digitization project: 80 of 100 batches are scanned, but 12 scanned batches await quality review and acceptance totals are unknown.

3. An executive update with a real ask - Fictional records project: the migration rehearsal passed, but the records owner has not selected which archive to retire.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A status date that is already old

A fictional executive report uses a staffing forecast prepared ten days ago. Two transfers have since been proposed but not confirmed. The dashboard refreshed this morning. Give an accurate verbal update on what is current and what is pending.

Role A: Reporting lead: explain the age and limits of the forecast.

Role B: Executive sponsor: ask whether today's dashboard refresh means staffing is confirmed.

Possible opening: The dashboard refreshed today, but its staffing forecast is ten days old and needs review.

Success checks

- Distinguish report refresh from forecast verification.
- Keep proposed staffing separate from confirmed staffing.
- End with a clear request for an updated owner-confirmed forecast.

Add a complication: The meeting chair asks you to describe the proposed transfers as secured resources.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Vendor and Cross-Functional Delivery

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A vendor says a deliverable is complete, but the team cannot find evidence for two acceptance criteria.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: deliverable, acceptance criteria, SLA, escalation.

Model response

Could you provide the evidence for these two criteria or identify any outstanding work? We need to review the deliverable against the agreed criteria before confirming acceptance.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. Complete without acceptance evidence - Fictional vendor review using the lesson case: the vendor calls a deliverable complete, but evidence for two acceptance criteria cannot be found.
2. Response time is not restoration time - Fictional support handoff: a draft summary confuses an acknowledged support ticket with restoration of the affected service; SLA wording has not been checked.

3. Training files that the receiving team cannot open - Fictional vendor delivery: training videos were uploaded, but the customer training team reports access denied; no content review has occurred.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A missing source-file handoff

A fictional vendor has supplied a final poster PDF, but the agreed deliverable also includes editable source files. Those files are missing. A campaign review is scheduled tomorrow afternoon. Make a specific request and agree a realistic checkpoint.

Role A: Campaign project manager: request the missing files for the receiving design team's use.

Role B: Vendor coordinator: confirm the gap and offer a progress update without promising files you have not located.

Possible opening: We received the PDF, but the editable source files in the acceptance checklist are still missing.

Success checks

- Name the missing deliverable and its purpose.
- Distinguish receipt from complete acceptance.
- Agree a timed update and route for any remaining gap.

Add a complication: The vendor offers a screenshot as a substitute for an editable file.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Post-Implementation Review

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

CASE

A project review repeatedly says "communication was poor." The team has no concrete improvement action.

Teach this move

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Vocabulary to check: postmortem, lesson learned, root cause, action item.

Model response

Which message or handoff caused difficulty, and what happened as a result? Let's turn that example into a specific change, assign an owner, and decide how we will check whether it helped.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Second-round challenge

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Language-check answers

1. A - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date. The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.
2. C - What is making this part of the task difficult? An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

05 • Conversations

1. Replace poor communication with an observable event - Fictional post-implementation review: the team has described communication as poor; a coordinator can identify a specific unshared schedule change.

2. The checklist was present but unused - Fictional review: a launch checklist existed, but the handoff meeting ended without reviewing its open access item.

3. A successful trial still needs a bounded lesson - Fictional review: one pilot team used a ten-minute daily dependency check and reported fewer missed handoffs; no comparison group was used.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The useful escalation came too late

In a fictional project, a resource conflict was raised two days before a workshop although it had been noticed a week earlier. The workshop was postponed. The reason for waiting is unknown. Discuss one improvement without blaming or inventing motives.

Role A: Review facilitator: ask for the observed sequence and separate it from suspected causes.

Role B: Workstream lead: propose an earlier escalation checkpoint and volunteer an owner.

Possible opening: We know when the conflict was noticed and raised, but we do not yet know why escalation waited.

Success checks

- Describe the sequence without attributing motives.
- Connect the late escalation to the documented scheduling effect.
- Agree an owned improvement and a way to review its usefulness.

Add a complication: A participant calls the delay proof that the team did not care.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.